

Global Aerospace & Defense

Space Exploration Technologies Corporation

Rating

Outperform

Price Target

SPCX

248.00 USD



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SpaceX: Flight 14 - Success to orbit; Starlink V3s deployed

SpaceX completed Starship Launch 14 on Monday, marking the third flight of the V3 configuration. This version is designed to deploy Starlink satellites, support future orbital data center launches, and deliver lunar and eventually Mars missions. Launch 13 largely repeated Launch 12. Launch 14 was a major step forward in Starship's capabilities. The booster had a successful splashdown. The Starship second stage lost one engine, which put the orbital goal at risk. But, SpaceX decided to go to orbit, as the engine affected was not to be used again in the flight. Starship successfully reached orbit for the first time, representing a key milestone for the program.

This first orbital mission appears to be largely a success. Despite an engine failure on the Starship and a shortened mission, most importantly Starship made it to orbit and deployed 26 Starlink V3 satellites. It did roughly two orbits around Earth (rather than planned six) in a 3-hour flight before splashing down in the Northern Pacific.

V3 satellites are central to SpaceX Connectivity growth. Each V3 satellite adds 1 Tbps, which is 10x the capacity of a current V2 mini satellite. Once Starship is fully operational, it is expected to deploy 60 V3 satellites per launch, rather than just 26. Deployment was on target at 277km altitude. Starlink thrusters will take the satellites up to roughly 350km, which is the planned constellation. This is below the current V2 mini constellation.

A critical part of this launch is performance of the heat shield in Starship reentry. While it appeared visually sound to us, tiles will need to be examined. Some tiles from Launch 13 were used on this flight to test behavior in reuse. We may see a catch of the second stage on Launch 15. But, that is not certain and will also depend on FAA approval. **Three engines failed in Launch 14:** Two of the 33 booster engines failed, as did one on Starship (but, not the center engines needed to go to orbit). We do not yet know the cause of the engine issues. But, **the FAA said the failures were not a sufficient aberration to require an investigation.** Still, the results will almost certainly play into decisions for Launch 15.

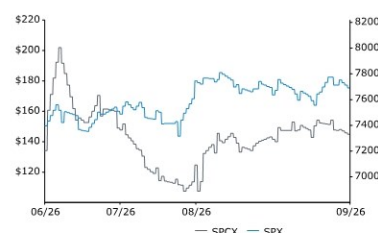
Investment Implications

We rate SpaceX Outperform, with a target of \$248. The main driver of our valuation remains orbital data centers, although Starlink provides substantial value. Starship reuse is key.

Close Date	28 Sep 2026			
SPCX Close Price (USD)	145.47			
Price Target (USD)	248.00			
Upside/(Downside)	70%			
52-Week Range	225.64/104.83			
SPX	7,683.69			
FYE	Dec			
Div Yield	NA			
Market Cap (USD) (B)	1,974.44			
EV (USD) (B)	1,913.79			
Performance	YTD	1M	6M	12M
Absolute (%)	NA	2.8	NA	NA
SPX (%)	12.2	(0.4)	20.6	15.7
Relative (%)	NA	3.2	NA	NA

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

Price Performance, 1YR



Adjusted EPS	F25A	F26E	F27E	Financials	F25A	F26E	F27E	CAGR	Valuation Metrics	F25A	F26E	F27E
SPCX (USD)	--	(0.19)	1.37	Revenues (M)	18,674	46,665	152,220	--	Adjusted P/E (x)	(765.6)	106.4	
				Adjusted EBITDA	6,584.0	21,360.0	87,689.0	--	EV/Adj EBITDA (x)	290.7	89.6	21.8

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

See the Disclosure Appendix of this report for required disclosures, analyst certifications and other important information. Alternatively, visit our [Global Research Disclosure Website](#).

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DETAILS

STARSHIP LAUNCH 14 - LARGELY SUCCESSFUL AS A STEP TOWARD FULL REUSE

Starship Launch 14 was an important next step in SpaceX's progression. The goal is for Starship to expand Starlink capabilities, create an orbital data center constellation, and eventually enable travel to the moon and Mars. This progression appears to be on track, although at a slightly slower pace than the company described early in the year. This slower pace is consistent with our expectations of eventual success, but on a longer timeline.

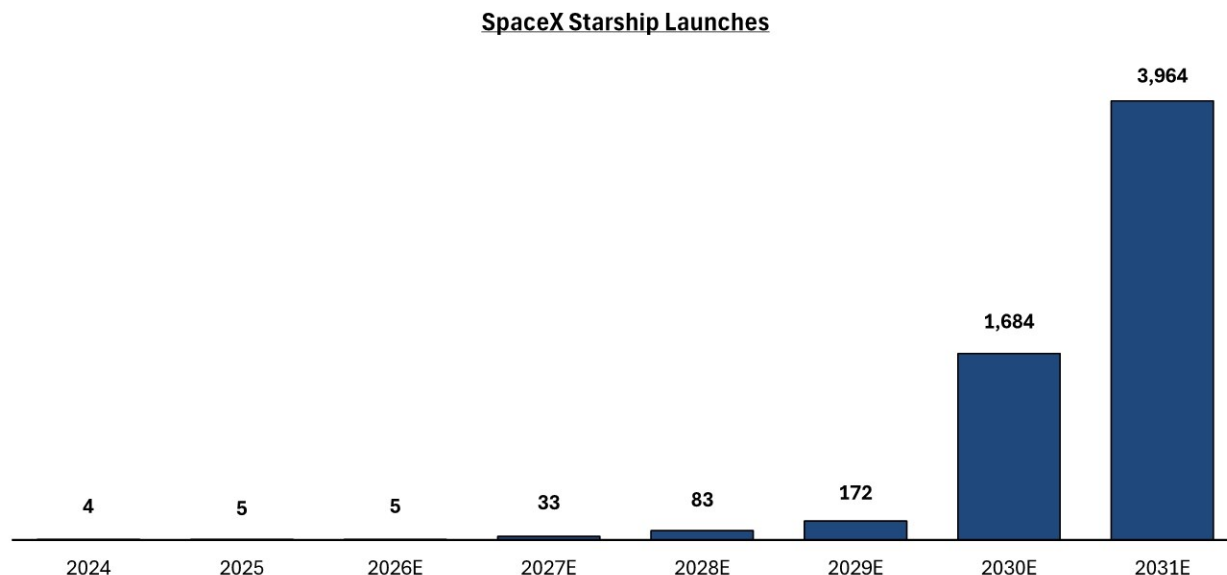
In the charts below, we show our expectations for Starship launches, which ramp to nearly 4,000 in 2031. This is, however, considerably below the rates targeted by the company (by more than a factor of two). Our slower rate, however, is still sufficient to make SpaceX a highly attractive stock. The company has said that it wants to be at one launch per day by the end of 2027. We are not expecting that rate until the end of 2029.

The key to all of this, however, is full reuse of both stages of Starship. Yesterday's Launch 14 is an important step forward. We will wait to see how the heat shield held up on the second stage. Then, we will look forward to a catch of that stage in a coming launch, which could be the next one. But, could also slip later in the year. Reuse of the second stage would be for 2027.

Although orbital data centers promise the greatest value creation, the Connectivity (Starlink) segment is also of high value. The first V3 satellites have now been deployed. We have discussed parts of Connectivity in detail, including the consumer broadband business ([SpaceX: Starlink's residential broadband business - How big can this become? Big!](#)) and the Direct to Device Mobile business ([SpaceX: Potential for MVNO D2D growth? Continuing our assessment of SpaceX Connectivity business and telco impact.](#)).

For a more comprehensive view on SpaceX, including the case for orbital data centers and our valuation methodology, please see our initiation report, "[Space Exploration Technologies Corporation: Doing Time in the Universal Mind - Initiate at Outperform; Target Price \\$239](#)". After Q2 reporting, we update our outlook in "[SpaceX: Upside from AI pricing, as Starship progress exceeds capex worries; Outperform, raising target to \\$248](#)".

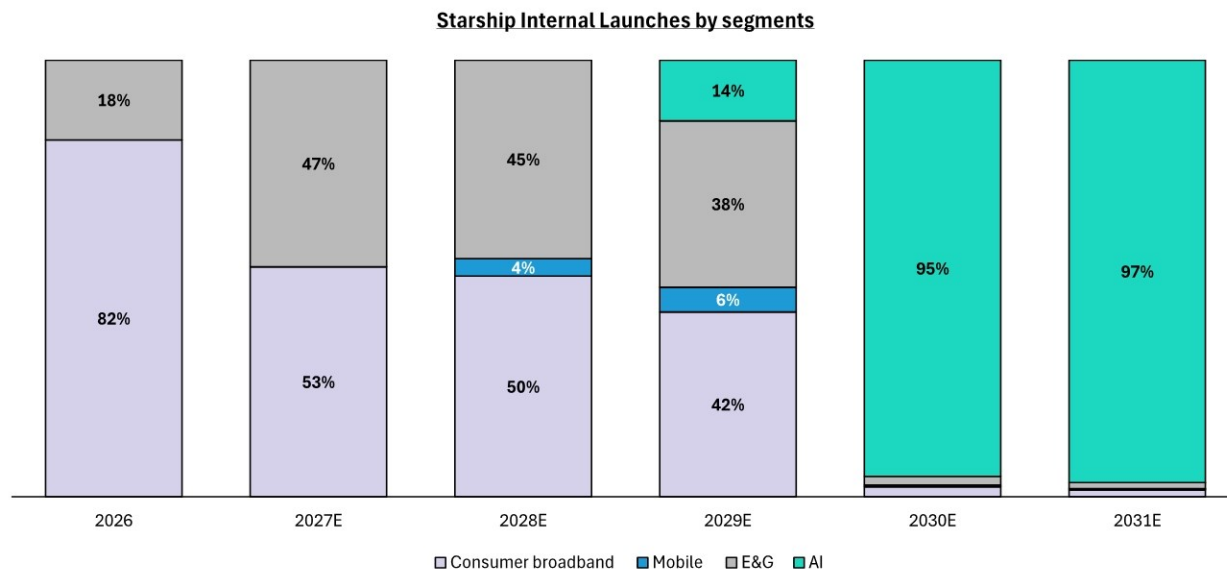
EXHIBIT 1: We expect Starship to have more than 3,900 launches in 2031



Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

We expect by 2030 that Starship launches will primarily be for orbital data centers. But, there will still be a substantial number (out of a very large total launch number) that will be used for Connectivity and other objectives.

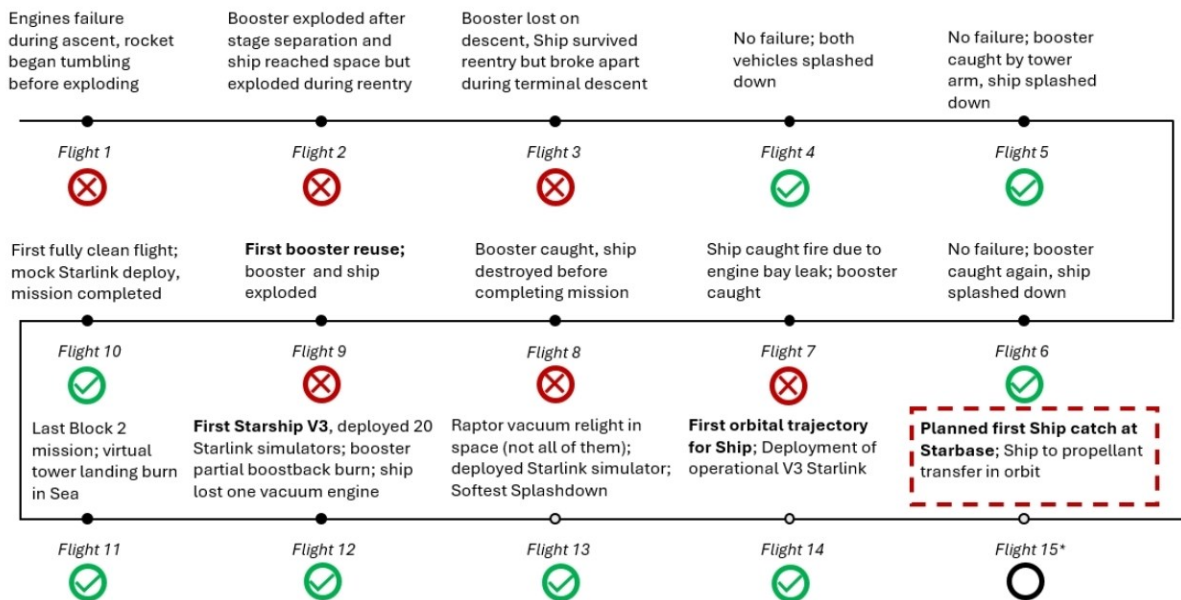
EXHIBIT 2: Short term Starship launches will be focused on expanding the Starlink constellation before focusing on orbital data centers from 2030 onwards



Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

Despite the shortened orbital trajectory, we see Launch 14 as a success. Heat shield performance will still be critical to assess. We may see a second stage catch on Launch 15, but that will depend on the SpaceX assessment of Launch 14 and FAA approval.

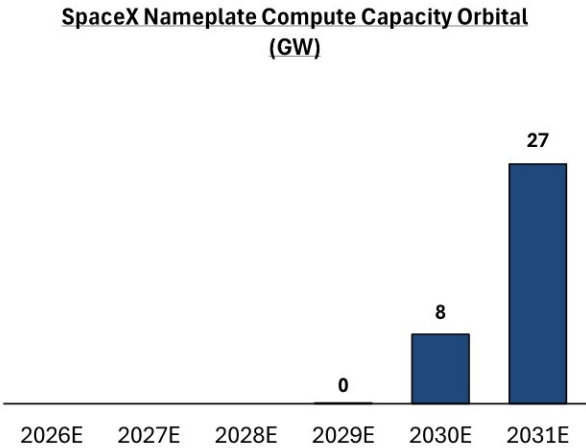
EXHIBIT 3: Flight 15 will be another key step for SpaceX which may have a second stage catch



Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

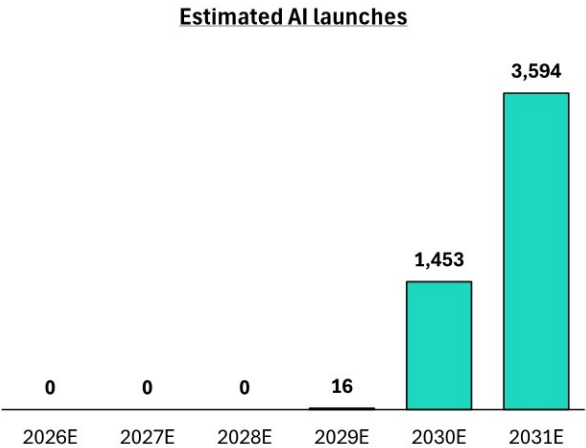
Our estimates for orbital compute capacity deployed are well below the company's projection.

EXHIBIT 4: **We expect SpaceX will add 27GW of orbital compute capacity in 2031 alone...**



Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 5: **This ramp-up will require an extensive amount of launches**



Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

APPENDIX - FINANCIAL FORECASTS

EXHIBIT 6: SpaceX Annual Income Statement

SpaceX Annual Income Statement (\$m)								
Fiscal Year Ending December 31	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E	2030E	2031E
Space	3,796	4,086	4,794	7,560	7,513	7,224	7,930	9,167
Connectivity	7,599	11,387	17,300	29,573	54,896	94,443	140,401	203,892
AI	2,620	3,201	24,571	115,088	195,835	229,164	305,581	439,753
Total Revenues	\$ 14,015	\$ 18,674	\$ 46,665	\$ 152,220	\$ 258,244	\$ 330,831	\$ 453,911	\$ 652,812
Cost of revenue	(7,996)	(9,451)	(17,298)	(47,599)	(81,772)	(101,588)	(123,789)	(178,107)
Research & Development	(3,464)	(8,643)	(23,219)	(67,278)	(49,327)	(61,756)	(77,503)	(110,420)
Selling, General, and administrative	(1,813)	(2,644)	(4,329)	(8,857)	(13,715)	(16,735)	(22,174)	(29,064)
Restructuring charges	(213)	(487)	9	-	-	-	-	-
Impairment	(63)	(38)	-	-	-	-	-	-
Total cost and expenses	-13,549	-21,263	-44,837	-123,733	-144,814	-180,079	-223,466	-317,591
Operating income	\$ 466	\$ (2,589)	\$ 1,827	\$ 28,487	\$ 113,430	\$ 150,752	\$ 230,446	\$ 335,221
Interest income (expense)	(1,209)	(1,453)	(2,129)	(11,511)	(16,320)	(22,010)	(20,989)	(20,796)
Other income (expense), net	985	-177	-1962	0	0	0	0	0
Income (loss) before income taxes	\$ 242	\$ (4,219)	\$ (2,263)	\$ 16,976	\$ 97,110	\$ 128,743	\$ 209,456	\$ 314,426
Provisions for (benefit from) income taxes	549	(718)	(82)	(99)	14,202	(2,414)	(4,828)	(39,563)
Net income	\$ 791	\$ (4,937)	\$ (2,346)	\$ 16,877	\$ 111,312	\$ 126,328	\$ 204,628	\$ 274,863
Shares outstanding (mn)								
Basic			11,789	11,789	11,789	11,789	11,789	11,789
Diluted			12,344	12,344	12,344	12,344	12,344	12,344
EPS (\$)								
Basic EPS			-0.20	1.43	9.44	10.72	17.36	23.32
Diluted EPS			-0.19	1.37	9.02	10.23	16.58	22.27
Adjusted EBITDA	\$ 5,350	\$ 6,584	\$ 21,360	\$ 86,684	\$ 181,219	\$ 233,623	\$ 338,766	\$ 485,873
Space	1,154	653	-561	2,817	3,122	2,939	3,768	4,556
Connectivity	3,849	7,168	10,674	18,177	31,961	53,366	77,877	113,623
AI	347	-1,237	11,247	65,690	146,136	177,318	257,120	367,694

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 7: SpaceX Quarterly Income Statement

SpaceX Quarterly Income Statement (\$m)											
Fiscal Year Ending December 31	2024					2025					2026E
	12 mo	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	12 mo	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	12 mo
Space	3,796	865	746	1,666	809	4,086	619	962	1,538	1,675	4,794
Connectivity	7,599	2,475	2,588	3,096	3,228	11,387	3,257	4,291	4,517	5,235	17,300
AI	2,620	727	737	814	923	3,201	818	2,561	6,713	14,479	24,571
Total Revenues	\$ 14,015	\$ 4,067	\$ 4,071	\$ 5,576	\$ 4,960	\$ 18,674	\$ 4,694	\$ 7,814	\$ 12,768	\$ 21,389	\$ 46,665
Cost of revenue	(7,996)	(1,962)	(2,282)	(2,706)	(2,501)	(9,451)	(2,388)	(3,495)	(4,624)	(6,791)	(17,298)
Research & Development	(3,464)	(1,557)	(1,958)	(2,291)	(2,837)	(8,643)	(3,514)	(3,548)	(5,494)	(10,664)	(23,219)
Selling, General, and administrative	(1,813)	(493)	(606)	(575)	(970)	(2,644)	(746)	(912)	(1,096)	(1,575)	(4,329)
Restructuring charges	(213)	(4)	(189)	(278)	(16)	(487)	11	(2)	-	-	9
Impairment	(63)	(24)	(6)	1	(9)	(38)	-	-	-	-	-
Total cost and expenses	-13,549	-4,040	-5,041	-5,849	-6,333	-21,263	-6,637	-7,957	-11,213	-19,030	-44,837
Operating income (loss) from operations	\$ 466	\$ 27	\$ (970)	\$ (273)	\$ (1,373)	\$ (2,589)	\$ (1,943)	\$ (143)	\$ 1,554	\$ 2,359	\$ 1,827
Interest income (expense)	(1,209)	(330)	(312)	(359)	(452)	(1,453)	(451)	(289)	(694)	(694)	(2,129)
Other income (expense), net	985	(211)	413	140	(519)	(177)	(1,876)	(86)	-	-	(1,962)
Income (loss) before income taxes	\$ 242	\$ (514)	\$ (869)	\$ (492)	\$ (2,344)	\$ (4,219)	\$ (4,270)	\$ (518)	\$ 860	\$ 1,665	\$ (2,263)
Provisions for (benefit from) income taxes	549	(14)	(138)	(562)	(4)	(718)	(6)	(23)	-	(53)	(82)
Net income	\$ 791	\$ (528)	\$ (1,007)	\$ (1,054)	\$ (2,348)	\$ (4,937)	\$ (4,276)	\$ (541)	\$ 860	\$ 1,611	\$ (2,346)
Shares outstanding (mn)											
Basic							4,496	5,864	11,789	11,789	11,789
Diluted							5,068	5,864	12,344	12,344	12,344
EPS (\$)											
Basic EPS							-\$0.95	-\$0.09	\$0.07	\$0.14	-\$0.20
Diluted EPS							-\$0.84	-\$0.09	\$0.07	\$0.13	-\$0.19
Adjusted EBITDA	5,350	1,730	1,212	2,168	1,474	6,584	1,127	3,538	6,841	9,854	21,360
Space	1,154	224	-94	672	-149	653	-351	-205	80	-85	-561
Connectivity	3,849	1,618	1,583	1,921	2,046	7,168	2,087	2,597	2,840	3,150	10,674
AI	347	-112	-277	-425	-423	-1,237	-609	1,146	3,921	6,789	11,247

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 8: **SpaceX Annual Cash Flow**

SpaceX Annual Cash Flow (\$m)								
Fiscal Year Ending December 31	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E	2030E	2031E
Net income (loss)	791	(4,937)	(2,346)	16,877	111,312	126,328	204,628	274,863
Depreciation & Amortization	3,824	6,701	16,646	54,913	64,009	78,682	103,673	145,575
Stock Based Compensation	784	1,947	2,896	3,284	3,779	4,189	4,647	5,077
Impairment & Other Charges	63	38	-	-	-	-	-	-
Non-Cash Interest Income and Other	(1,359)	947	1,433	(703)	(1,031)	(330)	(1,340)	(1,179)
Accounts Receivable	(347)	(543)	(2,384)	(4,378)	(10,550)	(8,573)	(11,585)	(1,372)
Inventory	(309)	(413)	(1,958)	(3,268)	1,907	976	45	908
Prepaid Expenses & Other	(328)	(673)	(354)	(1,520)	828	219	(223)	492
Accounts Payable	472	709	(3,513)	10,669	2,917	6,941	8,805	3,548
Deferred Revenue	1,876	1,929	15,136	16,283	(10,841)	(934)	10,908	(12,312)
Other Liabilities	309	1,080	5,764	4,352	(3,495)	(484)	731	(1,417)
Net cash provided by operating activities	\$ 5,776	\$ 6,785	\$ 31,320	\$ 96,509	\$ 158,835	\$ 207,014	\$ 320,288	\$ 414,183
Purchase of PPE	(11,163)	(20,619)	(90,673)	(268,514)	(285,881)	(330,060)	(376,298)	(416,668)
Other investing activities, net	367	1,044	(7,206)	-	-	-	-	-
Net cash used in investing activities	\$ (10,796)	\$ (19,575)	\$ (97,879)	\$ (268,514)	\$ (285,881)	\$ (330,060)	\$ (376,298)	\$ (416,668)
Debt Issuance / (Paydown)	(77)	9,131	17,041	170,588	198,712	142,241	149,406	(6,459)
Finance Lease Payments	(154)	(295)	(374)	(470)	(393)	-	-	-
Equity Issuance / (Repurchases) **	12,061	17,514	88,746	(1,653)	(2,432)	(2,553)	(2,123)	(2,781)
Net cash provided by financing activities	\$ 11,830	\$ 26,350	\$ 105,413	\$ 168,465	\$ 195,887	\$ 139,687	\$ 147,284	\$ (9,241)
Effect of exchange rate changes on cash and cash equivalents	1	63	(42)	-	-	-	-	-
Net change in cash and cash equivalents and restricted cash	\$ 6,811	\$ 13,623	\$ 38,812	\$ (3,539)	\$ 68,841	\$ 16,641	\$ 91,273	\$ (11,726)
Cash and cash equivalents and restricted cash, beginning year	\$ 4,690	\$ 11,501	\$ 25,124	\$ 63,936	\$ 60,397	\$ 129,237	\$ 145,878	\$ 237,151
Cash and cash equivalents and restricted cash, end year	\$ 11,501	\$ 25,124	\$ 63,936	\$ 60,397	\$ 129,237	\$ 145,878	\$ 237,151	\$ 225,425
FCF	(5,387)	(13,834)	(59,353)	(172,005)	(127,046)	(123,046)	(56,010)	(2,485)
Conversion to net income %	-681%	280%	2530%	-1019%	-114%	-97%	-27%	-1%
Working Capital	(12,177)	(20,272)	(32,963)	(55,101)	(35,867)	(34,012)	(42,692)	(32,540)

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 9: **SpaceX Annual Balance Sheet**

SpaceX Annual Balance Sheet (\$m)								
Fiscal Year Ending December 31	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E	2030E	2031E
Cash and cash equivalents	11,385	24,747	63,180	59,641	128,482	145,122	236,396	224,669
Marketable securities	800	0	6,487	6,487	6,487	6,487	6,487	6,487
Account receivables (net allowance credit loss)	1,052	1,579	3,963	8,341	18,891	27,464	39,049	40,421
Inventory	2,003	2,416	4,374	7,642	5,735	4,759	4,714	3,806
Prepaid expenses and other current assets	868	2,210	2,564	4,084	3,257	3,038	3,261	2,768
Total current assets	16,108	30,952	80,569	86,195	162,851	186,870	289,906	278,152
Property, plant, and equipment, net	21,147	42,602	116,629	330,230	552,102	803,480	1,076,105	1,347,199
Finance lease right-of-use assets	1,686	1,260	892	533	0	0	0	0
Intangible assets, net	2,211	1,548	0	0	0	0	0	0
Digital assets	1,749	1,637	0	0	0	0	0	0
Goodwill	11,129	11,809	0	0	0	0	0	0
Other assets	2,336	2,130	16,390	16,007	1,836	9,700	17,685	25,737
Total non current assets	40,258	60,986	133,911	346,770	553,938	813,180	1,093,790	1,372,936
Total assets	56,366	91,938	214,480	432,964	716,789	1,000,050	1,383,696	1,651,088
Accounts payable	4,413	11,792	8,279	18,948	21,866	28,807	37,611	41,160
Deferred revenue, current	10,179	12,116	27,252	43,535	32,694	31,760	42,668	30,356
Accrued expenses and other liabilities	1,508	2,569	8,333	12,685	9,190	8,706	9,437	8,020
Total current liabilities	16,100	26,477	43,865	75,168	63,750	69,272	89,716	79,535
Debt	12,262	21,659	38,700	209,288	408,001	550,241	699,647	693,188
Finance Lease Liabilities	1,531	1,237	752	393	0	0	0	0
Deferred Tax Liability / (Asset)	-725	-113	8	84	-14,305	-5,136	4,032	13,201
Other Long-Term Liabilities	1,394	1,353	1,293	1,293	1,293	1,293	1,293	1,293
Total non-current liabilities	14,462	24,136	40,753	211,058	394,989	546,398	704,973	707,682
Total liabilities	30,562	50,613	84,618	286,226	458,738	615,670	794,689	787,217
Convertible Preferred Stock	20,941	38,752	0	0	0	0	0	0
Additional Paid-in Capital	35,868	37,710	167,344	167,344	167,344	167,344	167,344	167,344
Retained Earnings	-31,005	-35,137	-37,483	-20,605	90,707	217,035	421,663	696,526
Total shareholders' equity	25,804	41,325	129,861	146,739	258,051	384,379	589,007	863,870
Total liabilities and equity	56,366	91,938	214,479	432,965	716,789	1,000,050	1,383,696	1,651,087
Total Debt	13,793	22,896	39,452	209,681	408,001	550,241	699,647	693,188
Net debt	2,408	-1,851	-23,728	150,041	279,519	405,119	463,252	468,519

Source: Company reports, Bernstein analysis and estimates

BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

			28 Sep 2026		TTM	Adjusted EPS				Adjusted P/E (x)		
			Closing	Price	Rel.							
Ticker	Rating	Cur	Price	Target	Perf.	Cur	2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
SPCX (SpaceX)	O	USD	145.47	248.00	NA	USD		(0.19)	1.37		(765.6)	106.4
SPX			7,683.69									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

DISCLOSURE APPENDIX

I. REQUIRED DISCLOSURES

References to "Bernstein" or the "Firm" in these disclosures relate to the following entities: Bernstein Institutional Services LLC (April 1, 2024 onwards), Sanford C. Bernstein & Co., LLC (pre April 1, 2024), Bernstein Autonomous LLP, BSG France S.A. (April 1, 2024 onwards), Sanford C. Bernstein (Hong Kong) Limited 盛博香港有限公司, Sanford C. Bernstein (Canada) Limited, Sanford C. Bernstein (India) Private Limited (SEBI registration no. INH000006378), Sanford C. Bernstein (Singapore) Private Limited, Sanford C. Bernstein Japan KK (サンフォード・C・バーンスタイン株式会社) and analysts employed by Société Générale Africa Technologies & Services to produce Bernstein research under a Global Services Agreement in place between Bernstein and Société Générale.

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VALUATION METHODOLOGY**Space Exploration Technologies Corporation**

We base our valuation approach on 12-month forward EV/EBITDA applied to 2031 EBITDA. We believe it is necessary to use a long-term period (i.e., 2031) because the cornerstone of the value is in the orbital data centers. Applying a multiple to, say, 2028 EBITDA would not capture any of that business - i.e., it would simply be space launch, terrestrial compute and near-term Starlink. We use a sum of the parts methodology to give an EV/EBITDA valuation in 2030 (based on 2031 values). We then discount that valuation backward for each segment to mid-2027 in order to reach a one year target price of \$248.

RISKS**Space Exploration Technologies Corporation**

Downside Risks to our Outperform rating and \$248 price target include the ability to dramatically growth Starship launch capacity over time, which depends on full reusability. SpaceX must be able to operationalize its orbital data centers to deliver on the valuation. Semiconductor availability could also be a constraint, as could other potential supply chain issues. There are also risks associated with potential launch incidents or regulatory restrictions. Should compute demand be more limited than most expectations, that would form another risk.

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The Bernstein brand rates stocks based on forecasts of relative performance for the next 12 months versus the S&P 500 for stocks listed on the U.S. and Canadian exchanges, versus the Bloomberg Europe Developed Markets Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index EUR (EDME) for stocks listed on the European exchanges and emerging markets exchanges outside of the Asia Pacific region, versus the Bloomberg Japan Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index USD (JPL) for stocks listed on the Japanese exchanges, and versus the Bloomberg Asia ex-Japan Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index (ASIAX) for stocks listed on the Asian (ex-Japan) exchanges -unless otherwise specified.

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- Outperform: Stock will outpace the market index by more than 15 pp
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The Autonomous brand has three categories of common stock ratings:

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- Neutral (N): The total return of the preferred instrument is expected to perform in line with preferred securities of other issuers operating in similar sectors or rating categories over the next six months.
- Underperform (UP): The total return of the preferred instrument is expected to underperform preferred securities of other issuers operating in similar sectors or rating categories over the next six months.

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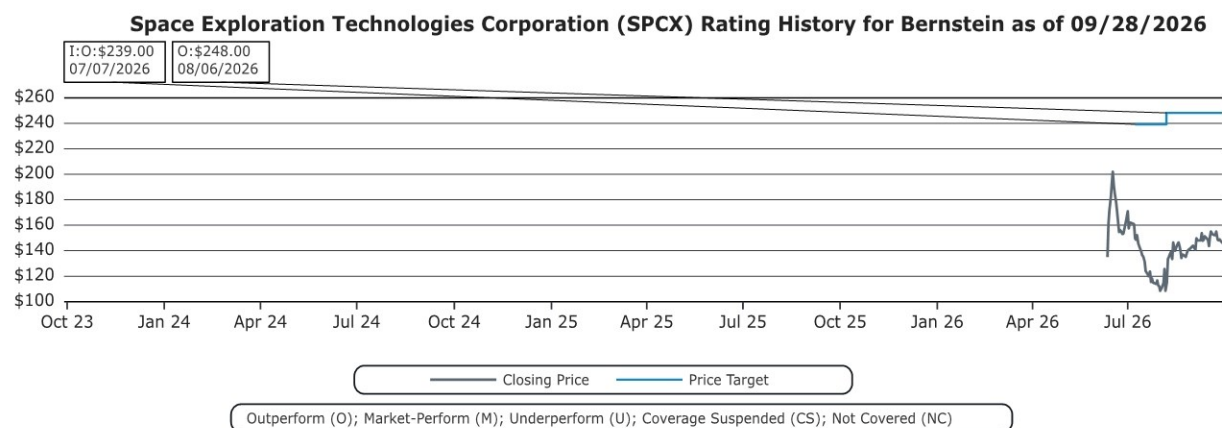
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Underperform	SELL	13.1%	13.6%

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